

Don't forget that the average person gets married in his or her late twenties or early thirties. That's also the time they're carrying around a lot of debt, especially student loans, credit cards, and, potentially, a new mortgage. Blunt, honest money conversations should put you and your loved one on the same page financially. But the one thing you both need to align on is this: Prioritize paying down debt. You must both agree to delay big holidays or buying that boat—or even a house—until that debt is paid off. If you do that, your marriage will be on much stronger footing, and it'll likely stay there.

Money Mistake: You Don't Think You Need a Prenup

THE FIX: TREAT MARRIAGE LIKE A SMALL BUSINESS

According to the Bureau of Labor Statistics, only 49 percent of small businesses survive longer than five years. Those aren't great odds, which is why you would never get into business with someone on pure faith alone. When you enter into professional partnerships, you get everything in writing, before your small business even earns a dime.

So what other institution has an equally high failure rate after five years? Marriage. We all think we'll beat the odds, that we're different, special, that our love is uniquely suited to withstand the trials and tribulations of life. And I'm nothing if not a romantic at heart (believe it or not). That's why I love entrepreneurs so much—their stories, their gusto, their passion for a project, an idea, or a product. But I don't hand over a dime before performing thorough due diligence, without consulting trusted advisors, before getting every single detail of a business plan in writing. I go into every venture protecting myself against grand claims and probable changes of fortune. You'd be insane to do otherwise.

So why do so many people get married without doing the same kind of due diligence regarding their life partner? Why do many forgo a prenuptial agreement? Sometimes they say prenuptial agreements are for people who have a lot of assets to protect. Wrong. In this day and age, when so many women are outearning men and buying property